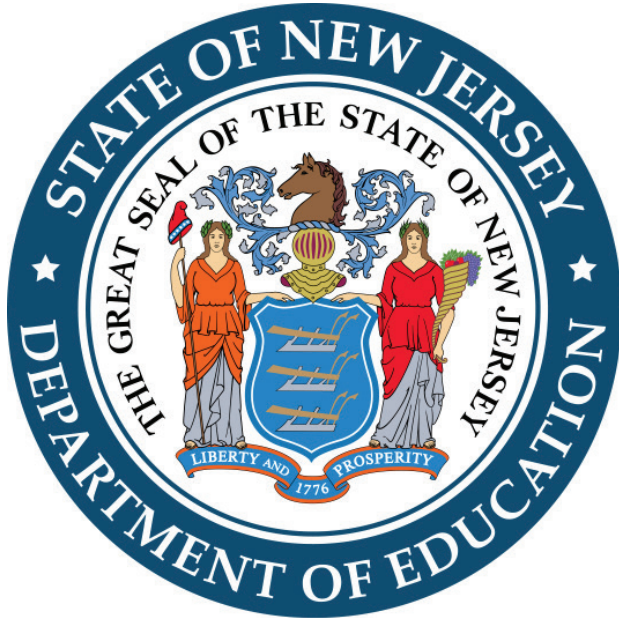




New Jersey  
Student Learning  
Assessments-Adaptive

# Practice Test

English Language Arts

Grade 8

Student Name \_\_\_\_\_

**Directions:**

Today, you will take the Grade 8 English Language Arts Practice Test. If you do not know the answer to a question, skip it and go on to the next question. If you have time, go back to the questions you skipped and try to answer them before turning in your Student Test Booklet.

1. Read each passage and question. Then, follow the directions to answer each question.
2. Fill in the circle next to your answer choice or choices.
  - If you change your answer, make sure you erase your old answer completely.
  - Do not cross out or make any marks on the other choices.
3. One of the questions will ask you to write your answer.
  - Write your answer in the space provided in your Student Test Booklet.
  - Be sure to keep your answer within the provided space.

# Maple and Marmalade

by Fiona Mulley

- 1        A loud knock sounded on Violet’s dressing-room door. “Places for Act One!”
- 2        Violet leapt up from her dressing-table stool, her breath quickening. A little shiver of nervous excitement ran down her spine as she peered into the mirror one last time, checking anxiously to see that her microphone was in place. She didn’t look quite like herself; the reflection staring back at her from inside the frame of lights was not the image of a thirteen-year-old girl but that of a young Civil-War-era woman. What with the stage makeup, full hoop skirt, and her normally loose hair gathered into a stately bun, she scarcely recognized herself.
- 3        Violet slipped her hand into the hidden pocket in her costume and groped about, closing her fingers around a pebble-like object. It was a small piece of wood, its surface was smooth and soft; the bark had been whittled away. She drew it out of her pocket and gazed at it wistfully, slipping into a reverie.
- 4        She could remember vividly the day she had received it from her best friend, Thomas. It was an October afternoon; they were sitting on a hill beneath a maple tree, and the ground was carpeted with crimson leaves. It was a favorite spot of theirs, and that day they had both rushed to meet each other there, almost bursting with bottled-up excitement.
- 5        “I have a secret to tell you!” Violet had gasped, grasping his hand.
- 6        “I have one, too. An important one. But you tell first,” he insisted.
- 7        As they settled down on the ground, Thomas pulled his Swiss Army knife out of his pocket, picked up a stick that lay nearby, and began to whittle. Violet smiled as she watched him absentmindedly work away; it was a hobby of his. He was always carving at something during their conversations. The end result was never more than a naked, pointed twig, but Violet found the habit endearing. “Tell away,” he said, looking at her expectantly.
- 8        Violet leaned forward on her elbows and said in hushed excitement, “You know how I auditioned for the musical *Little Women*? The cast list came out today. I got my first lead role ever! I’m playing Marmee!”
- 9        Thomas snickered. “Who on earth is Marmalade?”
- 10       Violet slapped his knee reproachfully. “Not Marmalade! Marmee! How can you not know who she is? She is the most inspiring character in the history of literature!”

- 11 Thomas raised his eyebrows, smiling his signature lopsided grin.
- 12 “She’s the matriarch of the March family in *Little Women*,” Violet continued to gush enthusiastically, her eyes locked on Thomas’s hands as they continued to shave off slender ribbons of bark . . . . “When her husband goes away to fight in the Civil War, she’s left to take care of the family herself. She’s so encouraging to me; she’s so strong and good and wise. She is always doing little things for others and guiding those around her. I want to be like her. And I get to play her!” Violet clasped her hands and lapsed into blissful silence.
- 13 Thomas chuckled at her enthrallment, shaping the twig into a point, like a pencil. “Well then, good for you! I always knew you could do it!”
- 14 Violet smiled, feeling warm and content inside. “What about you?” she asked Thomas. “You said you had news for me, too.”
- 15 Thomas cleared his throat a trifle nervously. “Uh, I’m moving.”
- 16 Violet stopped. “What?”
- 17 Thomas fixated his gaze on his whittling, somewhat flustered, as he continued to carve away at the stick, which was rapidly decreasing in size. “It’s just been finalized. We’re moving to Oakbridge, two hours away. We leave in about a month.”
- 18 Violet’s excitement faded away immediately. She didn’t say anything right away, but stared off into the distance, her chin cupped in her hands. She couldn’t imagine life without him. They had been best friends since kindergarten, and he had become like a brother to her. She had so many joyful memories of them together . . . . She remembered giving him a lesson on baking snickerdoodles that included Thomas swiping cookies, just out of the oven, off the sheet when she wasn’t looking, and then complaining about his burnt fingers. She remembered how he had been in the audience for every musical she had been in, despite all of her small, unimportant roles, and how she would rush eagerly to the lobby afterwards, where she knew he would be waiting with endless praise and a somewhat painful slap on the shoulder. Violet breathed a shallow, shaky sigh. She had finally landed a lead role, something she had been working for and dreaming about for years, and he wouldn’t be there to see her.
- 19 Thomas was quiet, too, as he used slow, deliberate strokes towards his thumb to round the edges of the piece of maple. It was hardly more than a pebble by now; the shavings lay in a heap on the grass. Thomas finished, slipping his knife away into his pocket, and examined his work keenly. It was like a wooden jelly bean, with a little dent in the middle. The surface was smooth and somewhat shiny. Thomas rubbed his thumb over it, smiled

slightly as if satisfied, and turned it over in his hand, contemplating what to do with it. At a loss for words, he turned to Violet and held it out in his palm. "Want it?"

- 20 Violet turned it over in her hand, smiling at it in a melancholy way. It was just a small token of their friendship, but it meant a lot to her. She slid it into her pocket, resolving to carry it with her wherever she went when Thomas had gone, like a talisman.<sup>1</sup>

<sup>1</sup> talisman: an object that someone holds as a way to bring good luck

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1. Read this sentence from the passage.

“Places for Act One!” (paragraph 1)

What purposes are served by this line of dialogue? Select **two**.

- Ⓐ to create a sense of surprise
- Ⓑ to emphasize a feeling of anger
- Ⓒ to hint about an event from the past
- Ⓓ to establish that the character is an actor
- Ⓔ to suggest what may happen in the future

2. Which phrase from the passage conveys Violet and Thomas’s enthusiasm about sharing news with each other?

- Ⓐ “almost bursting with bottled-up excitement” (paragraph 4)
- Ⓑ “settled down on the ground” (paragraph 7)
- Ⓒ “warm and content inside” (paragraph 14)
- Ⓓ “smiled slightly” (paragraph 19)

3. Which dialogue shows that Thomas encourages Violet’s dreams?

- Ⓐ “‘Tell away,’ he said, looking at her expectantly.” (paragraph 7)
- Ⓑ “‘The cast list came out today. I got my first lead role ever!’” (paragraph 8)
- Ⓒ “‘Well then, good for you! I always knew you could do it!’” (paragraph 13)
- Ⓓ “‘You said you had news for me, too.’” (paragraph 14)

4. Which sentence from the passage suggests that Violet misses Thomas after he moves?
- Ⓐ "Violet slipped her hand into the hidden pocket in her costume and groped about, closing her fingers around a pebble-like object." (paragraph 3)
  - Ⓑ "The end result was never more than a naked, pointed twig, but Violet found the habit endearing." (paragraph 7)
  - Ⓒ "Violet slapped his knee reproachfully." (paragraph 10)
  - Ⓓ "Violet clasped her hands and lapsed into blissful silence." (paragraph 12)

5. This question has two parts. First, answer Part A. Then, answer Part B.

**Part A**

What does the reader learn because the passage focuses on Violet's point of view?

- Ⓐ how much Violet values Thomas
- Ⓑ what Thomas appreciates about Violet
- Ⓒ how Violet became friends with Thomas
- Ⓓ why Thomas is moving away from Violet

**Part B**

Which sentence from the passage supports the answer in Part A?

- Ⓐ "A little shiver of nervous excitement ran down her spine as she peered into the mirror one last time, checking anxiously to see that her microphone was in place." (paragraph 2)
- Ⓑ "What with the stage makeup, full hoop skirt, and her normally loose hair gathered into a stately bun, she scarcely recognized herself." (paragraph 2)
- Ⓒ "She didn't say anything right away, but stared off into the distance, her chin cupped in her hands." (paragraph 18)
- Ⓓ "She had finally landed a lead role, something she had been working for and dreaming about for years, and he wouldn't be there to see her." (paragraph 18)



6. How is Violet's dialogue in paragraph 12 important to the passage?
- Ⓐ It explains why Violet has been selected for a role in a play.
  - Ⓑ It describes how Violet plans to research and prepare for a role.
  - Ⓒ It shows what Violet values and the kind of person she wants to be.
  - Ⓓ It suggests that Violet is interested in many different kinds of books.
7. How does the plot contribute to a theme of the passage?
- Ⓐ The conflict between Violet and Thomas causes the two to grow apart.
  - Ⓑ The flashback helps the reader understand Violet's feelings for Thomas.
  - Ⓒ The foreshadowing shows the reader that Violet and Thomas will remain friendly.
  - Ⓓ The dialogue suggests that Violet's interests are more important to her than Thomas is.

8. This question has two parts. First, answer Part A. Then, answer Part B.

**Part A**

Which statement **best** expresses a theme of the passage?

- Ⓐ Art makes life more beautiful.
- Ⓑ Getting to know someone takes time.
- Ⓒ Reading literature leads to new ideas.
- Ⓓ Friendship is something to be cherished.

**Part B**

Which sentence from the passage supports the answer in Part A?

- Ⓐ "Violet smiled as she watched him absentmindedly work away; it was a hobby of his." (paragraph 7)
- Ⓑ "Thomas raised his eyebrows, smiling his signature lopsided grin." (paragraph 11)
- Ⓒ "It was like a wooden jelly bean, with a little dent in the middle." (paragraph 19)
- Ⓓ "She slid it into her pocket, resolving to carry it with her wherever she went when Thomas had gone, like a talisman." (paragraph 20)

# Passage 1: Biofuels: The Ultimate in Recycling

by Jeanne Miller

- 1 Will there come a day when you can use the oil that your egg roll was fried in to power your car? How about the potato peels left over from making instant potatoes? . . .
- 2 In fact, that day already has come. Facilities that convert organic matter, called *biomass*, into clean-burning fuels are more and more often choosing to use waste products from other processes to produce *biofuels*.
- 3 Ethanol and biodiesel are the most common biofuels, and they provide environmentally friendly alternatives to gasoline and to petroleum diesel fuel. Best of all, using surplus materials to produce biofuels solves another big problem: what to do with all the waste we generate.
- 4 *Ethanol*, an alcohol, is produced after yeast or microbes break down a plant's sugars and starches. Combined with gasoline, it adds oxygen to the car engine's combustion process, allowing the fuel to burn more cleanly. A company in Idaho makes ethanol using potato waste from a nearby potato processing plant. A cheese factory in California makes it from unused whey.<sup>1</sup> Almost anything that ever grew can be processed to make ethanol.
- 5 *Biodiesel*, made from chemically altered plant oil or animal fat, is an alternative to petroleum diesel and will work in any diesel engine. When used as a substitute for petroleum, it reduces total air pollution by more than 50 percent and cancer-causing substances in the exhaust by 94 percent. About half of the biodiesel that's produced in this country is made from used vegetable oil.
- 6 Most intriguing of all is the oil produced by a machine developed by Changing World Technologies that uses a thermal depolymerization process (TDP) to take materials apart at the molecular level. The machine was designed to turn almost any waste product into high-quality oil, pure minerals, and clean water. It applies heat and pressure, the same forces nature employed to turn ancient vegetation into fossil fuels.
- 7 However, what took nature thousands or millions of years takes this machine a couple of hours. The company's Philadelphia plant has been operating for four years, taking in waste of all kinds: turkey innards, tires, city garbage, muck dredged up from the harbor, medical wastes. What comes out is light oil, gas, and minerals, all pure and harmless. A larger TDP plant in

<sup>1</sup>whey: watery part of milk after curds have formed and separated

Carthage, MI, expects to turn 200 tons of daily turkey-processing waste from the Butterball factory just down the road into 10 tons of gas; 21,000 gallons of water; 11 tons of minerals; and 600 barrels of petroleum and other oil. More plants are planned.

- 8 Although producing biofuels generally costs more than pumping petroleum out of the Earth, the added cost is offset by many benefits. These alternative fuels provide energy without harming our environment and depleting our country's resources. They offer the added bonus of solving our solid waste problems. It's a good deal for Planet Earth!

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## Passage 2: Biofuels: Fuel for the Future or Foolishness?

by Betty J. Pfeiffer

- 9 The United States is providing funds for the development and use of alternative fuels that will:
- provide energy that is sustainable (won't run out)
  - reduce greenhouse gas (GHG) emissions
  - reduce our dependence on foreign sources of energy.
- 10 Ethanol produced from corn is receiving the most attention, and the most money, from the government—but ethanol accomplishes none of the three goals!

### Unfriendly Ethanol

- 11 The problem with corn ethanol is that it takes about the same amount of fossil fuel to produce an equal amount of ethanol. This leaves us with no net gain in the reduction of carbon emissions, or our use of fossil fuel. . . .
- 12 But there are more problems with corn ethanol.
- 13 Corn requires more fertilizer to grow strong and healthy than any other major crop. About 40 percent of all nitrogen fertilizer used for growing our crops is used for corn, and the fertilizer is almost all fossil energy.
- 14 In spite of over 1,000 uses we have for corn and corn byproducts, about 20 percent of corn grown in the United States is now used to produce ethanol, up from 6.5 percent in 2000. . . .

**Beyond Ethanol**

- 15 Fortunately, many others are looking for different solutions. Dr. David Tilman has led a research group at the University of Minnesota (UMN) studying the use of prairie grasses as biofuel since 1994. The researchers have had exciting results!
- 16 These grasses can be grown on land that is too poor to grow anything else, saving the good land to grow food crops. They are *perennials*, meaning they grow back each year without replanting, so the farmer doesn't have to till the field. Without tilling, all the carbon the plants store in their roots stays there, rather than going back into our atmosphere.
- 17 This type of biomass is renewable (inexhaustible), almost without human effort. By growing mixtures of various plants together, energy yields were 238 percent greater than if just one type of grass was grown.
- 18 The prairie grasses were made into fuel without using gasoline, oil, or coal.
- 19 As an added bonus, the grassland biofuel is carbon negative because the plants sequester<sup>1</sup> more carbon dioxide in their roots than is released during the production of the biofuel.

<sup>1</sup>sequester: to seize or separate

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9. How does the author of Passage 1 show that biofuels help with waste management?
- Ⓐ She names some of the things biofuels can be made from.
  - Ⓑ She describes the impact of companies that make biofuels.
  - Ⓒ She describes how machines produce biofuels in efficient ways.
  - Ⓓ She explains how biofuels reduce toxic chemicals in the environment.
10. How does the author of Passage 1 respond to the negative view of biofuels?
- Ⓐ by showing that positive outcomes justify any costs
  - Ⓑ by pointing out that the argument is unsupported
  - Ⓒ by emphasizing the lack of other options
  - Ⓓ by presenting only one side of the issue
11. What is the meaning of the word organic as used in paragraph 2 of Passage 1?
- Ⓐ not produced in a factory
  - Ⓑ coming from living things
  - Ⓒ making energy naturally
  - Ⓓ chemical-free

**12.** This question has two parts. First, answer Part A. Then, answer Part B.

**Part A**

What is the position of the author of Passage 1 regarding the use of biofuels?

- Ⓐ Newer biofuels have the ability to generate more power than traditional fossil fuels.
- Ⓑ Biofuels provide solutions to issues of waste management and limited energy.
- Ⓒ Nearly any biological material or waste product can produce biofuels.
- Ⓓ Biofuel production mimics a natural process with faster results.

**Part B**

Which detail from Passage 1 supports the response in Part A?

- Ⓐ "A company in Idaho makes ethanol using potato waste from a nearby potato processing plant. A cheese factory in California makes it from unused whey." (paragraph 4)
- Ⓑ "When used as a substitute for petroleum, it reduces total air pollution by more than 50 percent and cancer-causing substances in the exhaust by 94 percent." (paragraph 5)
- Ⓒ "Most intriguing of all is the oil produced by a machine developed by Changing World Technologies that uses a thermal depolymerization process (TDP) to take materials apart at the molecular level." (paragraph 6)
- Ⓓ "Although producing biofuels generally costs more than pumping petroleum out of the Earth, the added cost is offset by many benefits." (paragraph 8)

- 13.** In Passage 2, the author argues that corn ethanol production takes the focus away from important food production. Fill in the circle **before** the sentence below that supports this claim.
- 11     Ⓐ The problem with corn ethanol is that it takes about the same amount of fossil fuel to produce an equal amount of ethanol. Ⓑ This leaves us with no net gain in the reduction of carbon emissions, or our use of fossil fuel. . . .
- 12     Ⓒ But there are more problems with corn ethanol.
- 13     Ⓓ Corn requires more fertilizer to grow strong and healthy than any other major crop. Ⓔ About 40 percent of all nitrogen fertilizer used for growing our crops is used for corn, and the fertilizer is almost all fossil energy.
- 14     Ⓕ In spite of over 1,000 uses we have for corn and corn byproducts, about 20 percent of corn grown in the United States is now used to produce ethanol, up from 6.5 percent in 2000. . . .
- 14.** According to Passage 2, why is corn ethanol unacceptable as a solution to today's energy problems?
- Ⓐ It costs the government too much money.
- Ⓑ It requires too many resources for its production.
- Ⓒ It discourages farmers from growing crops for food.
- Ⓓ It demands a guaranteed supply of corn every year.



- 15.** How does the author of Passage 2 lead the reader to think negatively about corn ethanol production?
- Ⓐ by listing the guidelines for government-approved alternative fuels
  - Ⓑ by focusing on how the use of corn ethanol affects individual consumers
  - Ⓒ by implying that government support for corn ethanol is politically motivated
  - Ⓓ by providing data about the environmentally unfriendly aspects of ethanol production

**Directions:**

Read the writing prompt and source. Then write your final essay on pages 23 through 25. Check over your essay when you are finished.

## Writing Prompt

Write a new story about a time when you were bored, including why you were bored and how you found a way to entertain yourself.

Manage your time carefully so that you can

- plan
- write
- revise
- edit

Be sure to include

- a logical sequence of events
- a strong narrator and character development
- a descriptive setting

Your response should be in the form of a multiparagraph story. Write your story in the space provided.

## A Boring Afternoon

Jeremy looked at the clock for the tenth time as he sat alone in the school library. He had agreed to meet Melissa to discuss their science project after she finished volleyball practice, not realizing how long that would take. There was at least another thirty minutes left. He had finished his homework, and just finished reading the book he kept in his backpack. This was going to be a painful afternoon if he had to wait with nothing to do. He sat staring at the minute hand, trying to notice as it moved across the clock face. If only he had finished his book yesterday, then he would have brought a new one with him. Then it hit him—he was in the library! He usually only came here with his class to find research materials, but of course he could find something here to keep himself entertained. After browsing for a few minutes, he found the perfect book. Sitting back down, he felt glad to have some time before Melissa would arrive.

**FINAL COPY**

This image shows a blank sheet of white paper with horizontal ruling lines. The lines are evenly spaced and run across the width of the page. There are no margins, text, or other markings on the paper.

**FINAL COPY**

This image shows a blank sheet of white paper with horizontal ruling lines. The lines are evenly spaced and run across the width of the page. There are no margins, text, or other markings on the paper.

FINAL COPY

Lined area for writing.



# Paper Practice Test Answer and Alignment Document: ELA

## Grade 8 Reading

### Passage: Maple and Marmalade

| Item Sequence | Answer Key             | Standards Alignment |
|---------------|------------------------|---------------------|
| 1             | D, E                   | RL.IT.8.3           |
| 2             | A                      | L.VI.8.4            |
| 3             | C                      | RL.IT.8.3           |
| 4             | A                      | RL.CR.8.1           |
| 5             | Part A: A<br>Part B: D | RL.PP.8.5           |
| 6             | C                      | RL.IT.8.3           |
| 7             | B                      | RL.CI.8.2           |
| 8             | Part A: D<br>Part B: D | RL.CI.8.2           |

### Passage 1: Biofuels: The Ultimate in Recycling

### Passage 2: Biofuels: Fuel for the Future or Foolishness?

| Item Sequence | Answer Key                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                               | Standards Alignment |
|---------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------|
| 9             | A                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        | RI.IT.8.3           |
| 10            | A                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        | RI.PP.8.5           |
| 11            | B                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        | L.VL.8.3            |
| 12            | Part A: B<br>Part B: A                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   | RI.PP.8.5           |
| 13            | <i>The student's response contains the following selection:</i> <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>In spite of over 1,000 uses we have for corn and corn byproducts, about 20 percent of corn grown in the United States is now used to produce ethanol, up from 6.5 percent in 2000. . . .</li></ul> | RI.CR.8.1           |
| 14            | B                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        | RI.CR.8.1           |
| 15            | D                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        | RI.PP.8.5           |

## Grade 8 Writing

Source: A Boring Afternoon

| Item Sequence | Answer Key                                        | Standards Alignment |
|---------------|---------------------------------------------------|---------------------|
| 1             | Refer to the grades 6-8 narrative writing rubric. | W.NW.8.3            |